

Board: 1

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: North

Board: 2

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: East

Board: 3

Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: South

Board: 4

Dealer: **West**

Contract: 4♥

Declarer: West

**Board 1**

North Deals

None Vul

♠ 10 9 6 3  
♥ 9 3  
♦ K 5  
♣ 10 9 8 4 2

♠ A J 4

♥ A K 7

♦ 10 7 4 2

♣ K J 3



♠ Q 7 5

♥ Q J 10 8 5 2

♦ A 3

♣ Q 5

♠ K 8 2

♥ 6 4

♦ Q J 9 8 6

♣ A 7 6

| West         | North | East | South |
|--------------|-------|------|-------|
|              | 1NT   | 2♥   | 3♦    |
| Pass         | 3NT   |      |       |
| All Pass     |       |      |       |
| 3NT by North |       |      |       |

Partner's 3♦ bid shows a 5-card suit and is forcing to game. While 5♦ is possibly the best contract your double ♥ stopper should sway you to 3NT instead. This is the old "9 tricks are easier than 11" principle.

North plays 3NT. As expected, East attacks in his ♥ suit.

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 6

Even if West holds both black Queens, (not likely), you can only finesse your way to 8 tricks. Since you need 9 tricks you must establish the ♦ suit.

If East holds both the ♦ A and ♦ K then you are going down, because they will win the race to establish ♥s before you can establish ♦s.

But when the ♦ A and ♦ K are in different hands you have a good chance for success; it depends on West having no ♥ at the time he takes his ♦ winner.

So you should hold up on the first ♥ trick and win the second. If East started with 6 ♥s then West will be out. So whether he wins his ♦ trick first or second he still won't be able to continue ♥s.

After your hold up West has no ♥s. If he takes the first ♦ trick he will have to lead another suit. You will still have a ♥ stopper for when East wins **HIS** ♦ trick.

On the other hand, if East takes the first ♦ trick he can certainly drive out your last ♥ stopper. But then, when West takes **HIS** ♦ winner he will have no ♥.

Finally, if East had only a 5-card ♥ suit, good defense would beat you. But they have to be sure West wins the first ♦ trick, and they might slip up.

**Board 2**  
East Deals  
N-S Vul

♠ K 5  
♥ J 7 5 3  
♦ Q 6 2  
♣ 8 5 4 2

♠ A 7 4  
♥ K 10 4 2  
♦ J 9 7 4  
♣ Q J



♠ J 9 6  
♥ A 8  
♦ A K 10 5 3  
♣ A K 6

♠ Q 10 8 3 2  
♥ Q 9 6  
♦ 8  
♣ 10 9 7 3

| West     | North | East | South |
|----------|-------|------|-------|
| 3♣       | Pass  | 2NT  | Pass  |
| 3NT      |       | 3♦   | Pass  |
| All Pass |       |      |       |

3NT by East  
Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 3 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 7

Partner's 2NT opening shows 20-21 points so you know you want to be in game. To find out which game you bid a Stayman 3♣. Partner replies 3♦.

Partner's 2NT opening shows 20-21 points so you know you want to be in game. To find out which game you bid a Stayman 3♣. Partner replies 3♦.

You don't have a 4-4 ♥ fit, so you bid 3NT.

The contract would be 3NT played by West.

East plays 3NT. South leads the ♠3. Your first problem is which ♠ to play from dummy. That is an easy problem. If you play the ♠K you might lose the first five or six tricks. If you play low you guarantee a ♠ stopper. North plays the ♠A and returns the ♠7 to dummy's ♠K. South plays the ♠2 on this trick.

You need 2 more winners, and you need to get them before you lose the lead because it appears that South can cash 3 more ♠ tricks.

That means you need all 5 ♦ tricks. The good news is that the 5 missing ♦s will split 3-2 about two-thirds of the time. The bad news is that they will be 4-1 about one-third of the time. Can you protect yourself against a 4-1 break?

Maybe and maybe not. If South has ♦ J x x x there won't be anything you can do about it. But if North has this holding then you can succeed if you play your cards right.

*Did you like that "play your cards right" quip?* First play a ♦ to your ♦K; both defenders follow. Next play a ♦ to dummy's ♦Q. South discards a ♣. You are conveniently in dummy so you play dummy's last ♦ and North's ♦ J 9 are caught in a pincer movement by your ♦ A 10 5.

It was important to play the ♦s exactly as described because dummy had only one entry left, the ♦Q.

Suppose your first ♦ play had been dummy's ♦Q. You could make your contract if you play a small ♦ and finesse the ♦10. But at that point you wouldn't know whether the ♦s were splitting evenly or not. You'd be risking defeat on a hand where everybody who played for the 3-2 split was making the contract.

By taking the **SECOND** ♦ trick with dummy's ♦Q the 4-1 split is exposed at the right time.

**Board 3**

South Deals

None Vul

♠ Q J 10 5 2

♥ 8 4

♦ J 8 3

♣ Q 9 6

♠ 8 4

♥ J 10 9 7 3

♦ 6 4 2

♣ K J 5



♠ 9 7

♥ K 6 5 2

♦ K Q 9

♣ 10 7 4 2

♠ A K 6 3

♥ A Q

♦ A 10 7 5

♣ A 8 3

| West     | North | East | South |
|----------|-------|------|-------|
|          |       |      | 2NT   |
| Pass     | 3♦    | Pass | 3♥    |
| Pass     | 3NT   |      |       |
| All Pass |       |      |       |

3NT by South

to dummy to finesse the ♥K, so you play the ♥A then the ♥Q, hoping a defender will grab their ♥K and set up three ♥ winners in dummy.

But they allow your ♥Q to hold the trick.

Now you are desperate. You need two entries to dummy, one so you can play ♥s to force out the ♥Q, and another to enjoy the good ♥s. One of these entries will be the ♣K and the second will have to be the ♣J. So you play a ♣ to the Jack and then you . . .

. . .

Lucky you. West held the ♣Q.

But don't get too smug. A lot of the plays work in these practice deals because they are set up to reward the correct Plan. In real life finesses only work half the time.

Partner's 3♦ bid is a transfer; you dutifully reply 3♥. Partner now bids 3NT.

Partner has just a 5-card ♥ suit. He doesn't have 4 ♠s or he would have used Stayman.

With no 8-card Major fit you pass 3NT.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♠Q on which East plays the ♠7.

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 6

You might get one more winner from the ♣ finesse, but basically you are going to have to establish dummy's ♥s.

You don't have the entries to think about going over

**Board 4**

West Deals

Both Vul

♠ A J 5  
♥ 7 5  
♦ A K 7 3  
♣ A J 4 2

♠ Q 10 7  
♥ K 9 8 2  
♦ J 10 8 2  
♣ Q 10

|   |   |   |
|---|---|---|
|   | N |   |
| W |   | E |
|   | S |   |

♠ 6 4 2  
♥ A Q J 10 6 3  
♦ 5 4  
♣ 7 3

♠ K 9 8 3  
♥ 4  
♦ Q 9 6  
♣ K 9 8 6 5

| West             | North | East | South |
|------------------|-------|------|-------|
| 1NT              | Pass  | 2♦   | Pass  |
| 2♥               | Pass  | 3♥   | Pass  |
| 4♥               |       |      |       |
| All Pass         |       |      |       |
| 4♥ by West hand. |       |      |       |

You have 9 points, an invitational strength hand. With 6 ♥s you transfer partner by bidding 2♦. Partner replies 2♥.

You have 9 points, an invitational strength hand. With 6 ♥s you transfer partner by bidding 2♦. Partner replies 2♥.

Remember, you have invitational strength, so even with a great trump suit you bid just 3♥. Partner puts it in game at 4♥.

The contract would be 4♥ played by East.

West plays 4♥. North leads the ♦J and South plays the ♦9.

Loser List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 4 Losers are as seen from dummy, the long-trump

You might get lucky in one of the black suits, but your best hope is that North holds the ♥K.

You win the first ♦ and play a ♥ to dummy's ♥10, which wins the trick. You smile. Return to your hand with the other ♦, then play your last ♥ to dummy's ♥J, which wins the trick. But this time you don't smile because South discards! North still holds ♥K 9 and you have no more ♥s to lead for a finesse. Does that finish you?

Never say die. Return to your hand with a black Ace and ruff a ♦ in dummy. Dummy's trumps are now ♥A Q 6 and North still has ♥K 9.

Back to your hand with the other black Ace and ruff another ♦ in dummy. Dummy's trumps are now ♥A Q and North still has ♥K 9. Play any black card from dummy, then sit back and wait for your two trump tricks!

Bad trump splits can sometimes be countered by a technique called a trump coup.

The coup is accomplished by ruffing to shorten the trump holding so you won't have to play trumps from that holding.

Pretty much like this hand.